

INTRODUCTION TO THEOLOGY

Comprehensive BTh Study Notes for the Indian Context

PART FOUR: General Introduction to the Bible

Prepared for Bachelor of Theology students. These notes are self-contained. This part explains what the Bible is, how many books it holds, why Catholics and Protestants count differently, how the canon was fixed, and how the Bible has traveled into the languages of the world, including, right here, into Bengali.

1. What the Word "Bible" Means

The word **Bible** has a surprisingly humble origin. It comes from **Byblos**, an ancient port city on the coast of what is now Lebanon, about forty kilometres from Beirut. Byblos was the great trading centre for **papyrus**, the reed-paper on which ancient books were written. Because the writing material came from Byblos, the Greeks called the material itself **biblos**, and a written scroll **biblion**. The plural, **biblia**, meant "the books."

When this plural word **biblia** passed into Latin and then into English, something beautiful happened. The plural "the books" came to be treated as a single word: **The Book**. So the very name of the Bible carries a mystery in it. It is **many** books (a whole library written across many centuries), and yet it is **one** Book, because one divine Author stands behind them all.

Key Points:

- **Bible** means simply "The Book," from the Greek **biblia**, "the books."
- The name reminds us of a paradox: the Bible is both a **library** of many books and a **single** unified Book.
- The unity comes from the one Author, God, who inspired the many human writers.

Indian Context Example:

India understands the reverence owed to a sacred book better than almost any culture on earth. Look at how the Sikhs treat the **Guru Granth Sahib**. It is not merely read; it is enthroned under a canopy, fanned with a **chaur**, put to rest at night, and treated as the living Guru itself. This intense reverence for the sacred book is a doorway for teaching Christians how to honour the Bible: not as one book among many on a shelf, but as the living Word of God to be received with awe. The Sikh care for the Granth Sahib can move a Christian to ask, "Do I treat the Word of God with such love?"

Illustration:

Think of a great national library made of many volumes, written by many hands over many years, in different styles, yet all catalogued as one collection because they serve one

purpose. The Bible is the library of salvation: many volumes, one story, one Author, one purpose, which is to lead us to God.

Application:

When you carry the Bible in procession, enthrone it at Mass, and kiss it after the Gospel, you are teaching your people, without a single word, that this is The Book above all books. Let your reverence for the physical Bible preach a silent homily.

2. How Many Books? The Catholic and Protestant Canons

Here is a fact that every BTh student must know clearly, because your people will ask you about it constantly, especially where Catholics and Protestants live side by side.

- The **Catholic** Bible has **73 books: 46** in the Old Testament and **27** in the New Testament.
- The **Protestant** Bible has **66 books: 39** in the Old Testament and **27** in the New Testament.

Notice that both agree perfectly on the **27 books of the New Testament**. The difference lies entirely in the Old Testament: the Catholic Bible has **seven more** Old Testament books than the Protestant Bible. These seven are called the **Deuterocanonical** books, from the Greek meaning "second canon," because their canonical status was affirmed at a later stage than the rest.

2.1 The Seven Deuterocanonical Books

Memorise these seven:

1. **Tobit**
2. **Judith**
3. **First Maccabees** (1 Maccabees)
4. **Second Maccabees** (2 Maccabees)
5. **The Wisdom of Solomon** (also called the Book of Wisdom)
6. **Sirach** (also called Ecclesiasticus)
7. **Baruch** (which includes the Letter of Jeremiah as its final chapter)

2.2 Why the Difference? The Catholic Account

The Catholic explanation of the difference rests on a historical point. The earliest Christians, who spoke Greek, read the Old Testament in its Greek translation, the **Septuagint** (often written **LXX**). The Septuagint **included** these seven deuterocanonical books. The Apostles themselves quote the Old Testament mostly from this Greek Septuagint. So these books were part of the Bible of the early Church from the beginning.

From this, Catholic teaching draws a striking conclusion: **Catholics did not add the seven books; Protestants removed them.** The historical record supports this claim in several ways. Martin Luther himself included these books in his first German translation. They appeared in the first King James Version of 1611 and in the Gutenberg Bible, the first printed Bible, produced a century before the Council of Trent. In fact, they were included, at least in an appendix, in almost every Protestant Bible until the Edinburgh Committee of the British and Foreign Bible Society removed them in 1825. It is therefore historically demonstrable, the Catholic argument runs, that the books were taken out, not added in.

Luther himself, in his Commentary on the Gospel of John, made a candid admission that Catholics love to quote: he granted that "the papists" possess the Word of God, which the Reformers had in fact received from them, and without whom they would have known nothing of it at all.¹

Key Points:

- Catholic Bible: **73** books. Protestant Bible: **66** books. The New Testament (**27**) is the same in both.
- The seven **Deuterocanonical** books (Tobit, Judith, 1 and 2 Maccabees, Wisdom, Sirach, Baruch) are the difference.
- The early Church used the **Septuagint**, which contained these books, so the Catholic position is that they belong to the original Christian Bible.

A note of fairness and charity:

Present this topic to your people accurately, but never with contempt. The Second Vatican Council teaches us to speak of Protestants as our **separated brethren**, who love Christ and revere the Scriptures they hold. Explaining why Catholics keep seven more books is a matter of teaching the truth in charity, not of scoring points. A good apologist wins the argument and keeps the friendship.

Indian Context Example:

India knows very well that different communities within one great tradition can honour different sets of sacred texts. Within Hinduism, all accept the **shruti** (the Vedas), yet the various **sampradayas** differ over which further texts they treat as authoritative. Vaishnavas, Shaivas, and Shaktas each privilege different Puranas and Agamas. The idea that one broad family of faith can hold a shared core plus disputed additional texts is already familiar to the Indian mind. This helps your students see the Catholic-Protestant canon difference not as something strange, but as a kind of question every scriptural community eventually faces.

Illustration:

Imagine two branches of one large joint family who inherit a bundle of ancestral letters. Both treasure the same main letters. But one branch keeps seven older letters in the bundle, while the other branch, at a certain point, sets those seven aside as less certain. Both branches are reading the family history; they simply disagree about seven documents. The Catholic claim is that the seven letters were in the original bundle all along.

Application:

When a neighbour says, "Your Catholic Bible has extra books," you now have a calm, historical answer: the early Church read the Greek Old Testament that contained them; they were removed only in 1825 from most Protestant printings. Say it kindly, and then invite your neighbour to read the beauty of Sirach and Wisdom for himself.

3. The Formation of the Canon

The word **canon** comes from a Greek word meaning a "measuring rod" or "rule." The canon of Scripture is the official, measured list of the books the Church accepts as inspired. How was this list fixed?

The decisive moment came at the **Council of Rome in A.D. 382**, under **Pope Saint Damasus**, with the help of **Saint Jerome** and **Saint Ambrose**. This council gave a complete list of the canonical books of both Testaments. That same council commissioned Jerome to compile and translate these books into Latin, producing the **Vulgate**. This canon list is also known as the **Decretum Gelasianum** (the Gelasian Decree), because it was later reproduced by Pope Gelasius in 495. Its list is **identical** to the list confirmed centuries later at the Council of Trent.

This same canon (46 Old Testament books and 27 New Testament books) was then ratified again and again across the centuries:

- **Council of Hippo** (393)
- **Councils of Carthage** (397 and 419)
- **Second Council of Nicaea** (787)
- **Council of Florence** (1442)
- **Council of Trent** (1546)

Here is an important distinction for the canon question. Regarding the **New Testament**, both Catholics and Protestants accept the decisions of the early Church (the Council of Rome and its successors). But regarding the **Old Testament**, the Protestant tradition follows a **Jewish** decision, associated with the so-called **Council of Jamnia**, rather than the canon of the Septuagint that the early Church used.

3.1 The Council of Jamnia (about A.D. 90 to 130)

After the Romans destroyed the Jerusalem Temple in A.D. 70, Judaism faced a crisis. Without the Temple, without its sacrifices, and without its priesthood, the surviving Jewish teachers had to reshape their faith around the study of Scripture. Jewish scholars gathering at **Jamnia** (Yavneh) worked to settle the canon of the Jewish Scriptures (the **TaNaK**) and to secure a Jewish future built on the text rather than the Temple. They faced two historical pressures at once: the **destruction of the Temple**, and the **rise and growth of Christianity**

within and around Judaism. The canon they favoured was the shorter, Hebrew one, which did not include the seven deuterocanonical books.

A scholarly caution to note for your students: Modern biblical scholars now debate whether "Jamnia" was a formal council that fixed the canon in a single act, or a more gradual process of consolidation. It is safest to teach it as the standard traditional account (as the course presents it) while noting honestly that the details are discussed among scholars. This honesty protects your students when they meet the debate later.

Key Points:

- The **canon** is the measured list of inspired books.
- The Catholic Old Testament and New Testament canon was fixed at the **Council of Rome (382)** under Pope Damasus and confirmed repeatedly, most famously at **Trent (1546)**.
- Catholics follow the **Septuagint** canon for the Old Testament; the Protestant tradition follows the shorter **Jewish (Jamnian)** canon for the Old Testament, while both agree on the New Testament.

Indian Context Example:

The Council of Jamnia is a case study in how a religious community re-forms its identity after catastrophe. When the Temple was destroyed, Judaism could have died; instead, its teachers gathered its sacred texts and rebuilt the faith around the book and the study-house. India has known such moments of reformulation too. When invasions and upheavals threatened ancient learning, it was often the careful gathering and guarding of texts in centres of study that preserved a tradition through the storm. The lesson is universal: when the outer structures fall, a people survives by returning to its sacred word. For the Jews it was the TaNaK; for the Christian it is the Bible.

Illustration:

Picture a great school whose main building burns down. The teachers cannot save the building, but they rush to save the library. Around those rescued books, they rebuild the whole school. Jamnia was that rescue of the library after the Temple burned.

Understanding this helps your students feel the seriousness of what a canon is: it is the rescued treasure around which a community rebuilds its life with God.

A little humour:

Students sometimes find the word "canon" confusing, because in English a **cannon** (with two n's) is a large gun. Tell them, with a smile, that the biblical **canon** has only one n, and it fires no cannonballs, only the measured truth of God. But add the serious point: in a spiritual sense the canon is indeed a powerful weapon, for "the word of God is living and active, sharper than any two-edged sword" (Hebrews 4:12, RSV-2CE).

Application:

When someone asks, "Who decided which books are in the Bible?", you can now answer with confidence: the Church, guided by the Holy Spirit, discerned the canon over the early centuries and fixed it at the Council of Rome, confirming it many times since. The Bible did not fall from heaven bound in leather. The Spirit guided the Church to recognise her own inspired books.

4. The Great Translations of the Bible

Because the Word of God is meant for all peoples, the Bible has always been a translated book. Learn these principal translations by name, language, and rough date.

- **The Septuagint (LXX):** the Greek translation of the Hebrew Old Testament, begun around **280 B.C.** It included the deuterocanonical books. Because it was widely used by Greek-speaking Jews even in Judea, it naturally became the Bible most used by the early Christians, and most Old Testament quotations in the New Testament are drawn from it.
- **The Vulgate:** the Latin translation by **Saint Jerome**, in the **fifth century A.D.** This became the official Bible of the Western Church for over a thousand years.
- **The Peshitta:** the **Syriac** translation, associated in the course with the **sixth century A.D.** It is the treasured Bible of the Syriac Churches, including the ancient Christian communities of India.

4.1 The Best Scholarly Texts Today

For serious study you should know the standard critical editions:

- For the **Old Testament** (Hebrew), the text nearest to the original, according to modern scholarship, is the **Biblia Hebraica Stuttgartensia** or the newer **Biblia Hebraica Quinta**.
- For the **New Testament** (Greek), the standard is the **Nestle-Aland**, currently the **28th edition** of the **Novum Testamentum Graece**.

4.2 The Bible in English and in Indian Languages

- The first major **English** version was the **King James Version** (Protestant, 1611).
- In **Malayalam**, the **Sathyavedapusthakam** was produced in 1910 by CMS missionaries (Protestant).

The Bible has now been translated, in whole or in part, into thousands of languages. The course gives the figure of **2,993 languages**. (This number keeps rising every year as translation work continues, so treat it as a snapshot rather than a fixed total. If you wish, I can look up the current figure for you.)

Key Points:

- The three great ancient translations to memorise: **Septuagint** (Greek, from about 280 B.C.), **Vulgate** (Latin, Jerome, 5th century), and **Peshitta** (Syriac).
- The standard scholarly texts today: **Biblia Hebraica Stuttgartensia** / **Quinta** for the Old Testament, and **Nestle-Aland (NA28)** for the New Testament.
- The Bible has been translated into thousands of languages, a number that keeps growing.

Indian Context Example (a local treasure for West Bengal):

Here the story of Bible translation comes almost to your own doorstep, Father-students of Barrackpore. Just across the Hooghly River lies **Serampore**, where in the early nineteenth century the great missionary **William Carey**, together with Joshua Marshman and William Ward (the famous "Serampore Trio"), ran the Serampore Mission Press. From that press poured Bible translations into **Bengali** (the complete Bengali Bible was finished in 1809) and into dozens of other Indian languages. Carey has been called the "father of modern missions," and much of the modern Bengali literary language was shaped by his translation labours. When you teach the translations of the Bible, do not leave the story in ancient Alexandria and Bethlehem. Bring it home: some of the greatest Bible translation in the history of the world happened a few kilometres from your seminary, in Bengali, the language of your own people. Though Carey was a Protestant, his devotion to putting the Word of God into the mother tongue of Bengal is something every Indian Christian can honour.

Illustration:

Imagine a life-giving river that refuses to stay in one channel. It branches into a thousand streams so that it can reach every distant field and village. Translation is the branching of the river of the Word, so that the water of life may reach the Bengali farmer, the Malayali fisherman, the Santhali forest-dweller, each in his own tongue. The Septuagint was the first great branching; the Serampore press was one of the greatest.

A piece of humour about the translator saints:

Saint Jerome, who gave us the Vulgate, was a holy man but famously **short-tempered**. He worked for years in a cave in Bethlehem and quarreled with almost everyone by letter. It is said, only half in jest, that Jerome was proof that God can make a great saint out of a difficult personality. There is also the charming legend that a lion once limped into his monastery with a thorn in its paw; Jerome removed the thorn, and the grateful lion became his lifelong companion. Historians doubt the lion, but seminarians love it, because it reminds us that even the crankiest scholar has a gentle heart hidden underneath, and that the labour of translating God's Word can tame even a lion of a temper.

There is also the delightful ancient legend about the Septuagint itself, told in the Letter of Aristeas: that seventy-two Jewish scholars were shut up separately to translate the Scriptures, and after seventy-two days each emerged with a translation **identical** to all the others, word for word. Scholars treat this as pious legend, but it makes a lovely point: the early community believed so deeply that God guided the translation that they told the story

as a miracle. Tell it with a smile, then make the serious point: translation is holy work, and the Church has always trusted the Spirit to guard it.

Application:

Your ministry in India will be, in part, a ministry of translation, not only of words but of meaning. You will stand before people who need the eternal Word rendered into the language of their daily lives, their struggles, and their culture. William Carey put the Word into Bengali print; your task is to put the Word into Bengali hearts. Honour the mother tongue of your people, for God chose to speak to humanity not in the abstract but in real languages that real mothers sing to their children.

PART FOUR SUMMARY: Main Takeaways

1. **Bible** means "The Book," from the Greek **biblia** ("the books"), by way of the papyrus port of **Byblos**. It is a library of many books and yet one Book, because of its one divine Author.
2. The **Catholic** Bible has **73 books** (46 + 27); the **Protestant** Bible has **66** (39 + 27). Both share the same **27** New Testament books. The difference is the **seven Deuterocanonical books**: Tobit, Judith, 1 and 2 Maccabees, Wisdom, Sirach, and Baruch.
3. The early Church used the **Septuagint**, which contained these seven books, so the Catholic position is that the books were **removed** by Protestants (finally in 1825), not **added** by Catholics.
4. The **canon** (the measured list of inspired books) was fixed at the **Council of Rome (382)** under Pope Damasus and confirmed many times, up to **Trent (1546)**. Catholics follow the **Septuagint** canon for the Old Testament; the Protestant tradition follows the shorter **Jewish (Jamnian)** canon, while both agree on the New Testament.
5. The three great ancient translations are the **Septuagint** (Greek), the **Vulgate** (Latin, Jerome), and the **Peshitta** (Syriac). The best scholarly texts today are **Biblia Hebraica Stuttgartensia / Quinta** and **Nestle-Aland (NA28)**.
6. The Bible has reached thousands of languages. For West Bengal, the crown jewel of the story is **William Carey and the Serampore press**, which gave the Bengali people their Bible in 1809, just across the river from Barrackpore.

A word to carry forward: The Bible is The Book, one and many, guarded as canon by the Spirit-led Church, and poured out through translation into every tongue, even into your own Bengali. Revere it as the Sikh reveres the Granth, defend its canon with charity, and give your life, as Carey gave his, to putting the Word of God into the language of your people.

End of Part Four. Part Five will treat the Inspiration of Scripture: the meaning of theopneustos (God-breathed), the divine and human authorship of the Bible, the biblical writers' own claims, the various theories of inspiration, and the doctrine of inerrancy, with the same Indian contextualisation and humour.

1. Martin Luther, *Commentary on the Gospel of St. John*, chapter 16, as commonly cited in Catholic apologetic literature on the transmission of Scripture. The remark concedes that the Reformers received the Scriptures through the (Catholic) Church. ↩